

AIBuilder Marketplace

The Honest SaaS Buyer's Handbook

Every pricing trick, defined and counted. The statistics vendors would rather you didn't have. The 182 genuinely free tools. And the checklist that keeps your software bill honest.

Edition: August 2026 · built from 406 hand-researched pricing dossiers · no invented numbers

Free forever at <https://aibuildermarketplace.com/handbook/> — subscribers get every new edition automatically.

1 • The six pricing tricks — and how often they occur

Counted across 406 hand-researched dossiers; every count is backed by an evidence sentence in the public dataset (CC BY 4.0).

Usage-based (metered) pricing [174 van 406 tools](#)

Credits, message counts, overage fees or percentage cuts on top of the plan. Fair when the meter is public; dangerous when it's buried. Always model your real volume before trusting the sticker.

Per-seat pricing [120 van 406 tools](#)

The bill scales with every user you add — a quiet tax on growth. Ask: does value really scale with headcount here? Flat-fee alternatives exist in most categories.

Paid add-ons [114 van 406 tools](#)

Key features sold separately: payroll on top of bookkeeping, verification on top of email. Price the bundle you actually need, never the base plan.

Annual lock-in [84 van 406 tools](#)

The advertised price only exists with a yearly commitment. You carry the risk: a year paid before you know if the tool sticks. Compute the monthly-billing premium before deciding.

Quote-only (hidden) pricing [23 van 406 tools](#)

No public price list — a sales call required. Enables per-customer pricing and makes comparison impossible. Budget serious evaluation time, and never enter that call without an anchor.

Renewal jump [13 van 406 tools](#)

The intro price is not the renewal price — standing practice in hosting and security. The only number that matters is year two. Put the renewal date in your calendar with a cancel window.

2 · The numbers (August 2026)

Tools with ≥ 1 documented cost caveat	76%
Meters usage on top of the subscription	43%
Charges per seat	30%
Sells key features as paid add-ons	28%
Requires annual commitment for the advertised price	21%
Publishes no usable price at all	6%
Has a genuinely free tier	45%

Only **24%** of tools have a sticker price that is also the whole story. Full methodology & live data:
<https://aibuildermarketplace.com/research/>

3 • The honest buyer's checklist

1. Find the real price: your volume, your seat count, the add-ons you need — not the sticker.
2. Check the meter: what happens at 2× your current usage? At 10×?
3. Read the renewal terms before the intro price seduces you. Year two is the real price.
4. Genuinely free tier? Test the actual workflow on it before paying anything.
5. Cancel-test: how many clicks to leave? If you can't find out, that's your answer.
6. One tool per job: name the job each subscription owns. Two tools, one job = one candidate to kill.
7. Calendar every renewal date with a 2-week cancel window (our free Renewal Radar generates the reminders).
8. Verify claims against evidence — ours or anyone's. A review without receipts is an ad.

The cancel-first test: unsure about a subscription? Cancel it. Re-subscribe if you genuinely miss it within a month. Most people never do — that silence is the honest verdict.

4 · The 182 genuinely free tools

Real free tiers you can run on indefinitely — not trials in a costume. Live links & dossiers:

<https://aibuildermarketplace.com/atlas/> (filter: Free tier).

Analytics

Amplitude

Business Operations

Boulevard

Communication & Voice

800.com, CometChat, CrankWheel, Fireflies.ai, Freshchat, Kixie, Readymode, Ruby, Signal House, Textline, ZenZap, eDesk

Content & Media

Audiorista, ElevenLabs

Customer Support

AskNest, Cloze, Gorgias, HelpCenter, StoreFAQ

Design & Content

AhaSlides, Modelize, Piktochart, Retouch4me, Section Library, Wegic

Developer Tools

Thordata, UptimeRobot

E-commerce

EcomXray, Pricify, Scarcity.AI, Selixer, Shipdock, Way, Zendrop

Finance

Airwallex

Financial Operations

Aspire, Bill.com, Compliancely, Dext, Disputifier, Melio, Payoneer, Tax1099, Zeffy

Growth & Revenue

AWeber, ActiveCampaign, AdCreative.ai, Apollo, Attribuly, Beefree, Beehiiv, Bookyourdata, Brevo, CallRail, Campaign Monitor, Capsule, Close, Crazy Egg, Essential Loyalty, ExpertSender, Gelato, GetResponse, Hello Bar, Iconosquare, Keap, Kit, Later, Leadpages, LearnWorlds, LettrLabs, ManyChat, Notify Me, Printify, PushOwl, Rank Math, Restream, Riverside, Seamless.ai, Selffy, Shorby, Stamped, Stampezee, Streak, Success.co, TicketTailor, VidPal, WhatConverts, ZoomInfo, iContact, lemlist

HR & People

Employment Hero, Insightful, Jibble, Leavo, TestGorilla

IT & Productivity

1Password, Airia, Blinq, Bright Data, Claude, Cloudways, Consensus, Devs.ai, Emergent, ExpertEx, Expertise AI, Getscreen, Glide, Hopp, IDrive, MindStudio, QuickSigner, Runpod, SMTP.com, SMTP2GO, Softr, WebCatalog, accessiBe

Marketing

Cloro, Dondy, EmailListVerify, Meeri, PagePulse, Pippit, Storista, TiXel, involve.me

Operations & Workflow

BackupMaster, Bokun, Breezy HR, ClickUp, Connecteam, Databox, Descript, FlexiQuiz, Gamma, Goflow, Hive, InVideo, Katana MRP, Miro, Momence, Murf, Pangram, QuillBot, Reclaim.ai, Sendcloud, ServiceM8, Shippo, SmartSuite, SurveyMonkey, Survicate, Switcher Studio, Team Pulse, Todoist, Toggl, Tradify, Turbotic, Wrike, ZenBusiness

Productivity

TextExpander

SEO & Marketing

AgentNest, Customer.io, Postscript, SEOMatic, StoreSEO, Tapita AI SEO Blog Builder, Tapita SEO Optimizer

Sales & CRM

EngageBay, Expandi, GrapeLeads, HubSpot, Spiky.ai, Storylane

Security

Blocky, EasyDMARC, Securify

Video & Audio

MeetGeek, Wistia

Website Builders

Webflow

5 · The Honest Software Awards 2026

No entry, no fees, no pay-to-play — winners drawn from the research corpus, each with its evidence:

Aisdr, Aisq, Beautiful Ai, Clickup, Contractor Foreman, Flocksy, Gamma, Jubilee, Kit, Landingi, Lindy Ai, Printify, Rank Math, Reclaim Ai, Signnow, Tax1099, Toggl

Categories & receipts: <https://aibuildermarketplace.com/awards/>

6 · Keep it honest, automatically

Everything in this handbook updates itself on the site: the [Atlas](#) (dossiers), [Price Watch](#) (documented hikes with archived receipts), [the statistics](#), and [Stack X-Ray](#) (audit what you already pay — in your browser).

One honest email a week — new dossiers, price-hike alerts and each new handbook edition:
<https://aibuildermarketplace.com> (newsletter box on every page).